

Menace and meaning are further conveyed through the use of song. Harry Powell appropriates a hymn "Leaning on the everlasting arms," which he sings to himself as he hunts the children, Pearl and John.

Powell uses his tattoos to tell a moralizing tale of love and hate, but Rachel Cooper can see right through him.

Its lyrics are about the peace and joy believers find in the arms of the Lord. In the small town that he infiltrates, Powell poses as a man of God whom the bereaved Willa can lean on as she copes with the loss of her husband, and whom the local community trusts with the care of the children after she

subsequently disappears. He appears to be the picture of charity, and a trusted authority figure—but his true intentions are to abuse, exploit, and steal.

Magical realism

As John and Pearl escape Powell's clutches in a rowboat that carries them away by river, their journey into a dangerous unknown is conveyed by song, rather than dialogue. Pearl sings of a fly soaring up to the moon. A tiny thing in a vast world, the fly does not know what perils lie before it, yet it goes anyway, for there is no other course. The song adds to the expressionistic feel of the movie, creating a sense of magical realism.

